

Inside the Checkpoint: Kannai and the Making of Yokohama

A fishing hamlet was chosen over its larger neighbor to keep foreign traders off the shogun's highway, and the customs post built to police the swap gave the district its name: Kannai, "inside the barrier." Reclaimed twice more, by treaty diplomacy and then by earthquake rubble, this ground still carries the grid the eighteen-fifties laid down.



関内・山下町（横浜市中区）

In this dossier

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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

A crossed beach becomes a village

Little here is original ground: the Geospatial Information Authority's landform survey reads more than half the study area as former water or sandbar and over half again as artificial fill. A 1913 history of the city traces the name Yokohama itself to this geography, describing a sandbar running northwest from the foot of a hill near today's Motomachi toward what is now a lighthouse-testing station, so that the spit of land lay crosswise, yoko, in the sea. Thirteen households fished here three centuries before the port opened; by the early Edo period the hamlet, once grouped with its neighbors as a single Ishikawa village, had split off as Yokohama-mura in its own right, with 87 households recorded by the account, hemmed by the coast, a tidal inlet, and two sister villages. A map of "Yokohama village and its surroundings" drawn up in 1851, preserved in the city's own historical archive, shows exactly this: a thin fishing settlement strung along the shore with open water and marsh on every other side, only eight years before it became the center of a treaty port.¹⁴⁸

A province older than the port

The wider region the fishing hamlet belonged to is documented far earlier than the hamlet itself. Gumyoji temple, a few kilometers inland, appears in a document of 1181 as a hereditary house of prayer for the Minamoto clan, and the Yokohama region passed in turn through the hands of Kamakura-period retainers, the Hojo regents, and, once the Ashikaga shogunate installed its own deputies as Kanto Kanrei, the Uesugi houses that served under them; a Hojo clan land register of 1559 still lists named vassals holding fiefs across the wider district by the time Hojo Soun's descendants dominated the whole of the Kanto region. None of this administrative history touched the little fishing settlement directly — Yokohama-mura was a footnote to all of it — until foreign treaties made its obscurity useful.²

The swap that named the district

The treaties Japan signed with Western powers in 1858 named Kanagawa, the substantial Tokaido post town a few kilometers north, as the port to open the following year. The shogunate had other ideas: an official named Mizuno Chikugo-no-kami, backed by the senior councillor Ii Naosuke, argued for substituting the smaller fishing village of Yokohama across the bay, chiefly to keep foreign residents away from the crowded highway that daimyo processions used. The American consul-general Townsend Harris and his British counterpart, Rutherford Alcock, protested hard: the treaty text said Kanagawa, Yokohama was unnamed and unsuited to trade, and keeping foreigners off the highway seemed to violate the spirit of friendship the treaties claimed. The shogunate answered that Yokohama was technically part of Kanagawa Bay, sat conveniently near Kamakura, Uraga and the scenic spots of Kanazawa and Enoshima, and made a naturally superior harbor — and then set out to prove it, building bridges, a wharf, five new streets, and, at the center of the reclaimed village, a customs house.¹

That customs house is the reason this district carries the name it does. Officials called Kanagawa Magistrates were installed to handle both foreign and domestic affairs from the middle of 1859, with a separate office at Tobe handling ordinary judicial business while the customs post in the heart of Yokohama village took charge of tariffs and foreign matters; the ground inside its checkpoint became Kannai, "inside the barrier," and everything beyond it Kangai. The tax breaks, reclaimed swampland and subsidised tenements worked: merchants and, eventually, the foreign consulates themselves abandoned their preference for Kanagawa, with the Dutch consulate agreeing to move to Yokohama in January 1861 (the twelfth month of 1860 by the old calendar) and the other powers following despite their own governments' instructions. No single day marks the change formally — historians of the port conventionally use 1 July 1859 (2 June by the old calendar, the date Yokohama still keeps as its official Port Opening Day), technically the date fixed for Kanagawa's own opening — but by the accepted terms of the deal it was Yokohama, not Kanagawa, that became Japan's first great treaty port.¹

A settlement, and the town beside it called Nankin-machi

Once the foreign settlement's layout was fixed, Yokohama village's own farming families were moved out to what are now Motomachi and Yamashita in 1860, and the district was built up southward in stages, largely complete by about 1863. Chinese residents, drawn first as compradors and laborers for other foreign trading houses, gathered naturally in one part of the new settlement — lots 120 to 160 along what is now Yamashita-cho — well before Japan and China had any treaty of their own; a formal treaty of amity and commerce between the two countries only followed on 13 September 1871. Trade then grew quickly enough that a Qing consulate opened at lot 135 in 1877, and by the years before the Sino-Japanese War of 1894-95 the quarter's population had reached 3,000, falling sharply when diplomatic relations broke off — about 500 residents stayed on under Japanese official protection — before recovering once the war ended. From 1899, when foreigners gained the right to live and trade anywhere in Japan, Japanese shopkeepers moved into the district too, and by around 1907 it held some 350 households and 4,000 people; on the eve of the 1923 earthquake, the population is put at about 5,000.³

Contemporary Yokohama called the quarter Nankin-machi, after Nanjing and the south Chinese coast most of its early residents came from, rather than the generic "China town" used elsewhere in Japan. An official 1933 account of the city's customs describes its busiest block, along lots 143 to 154, as a row of two-storey red-brick shops decorated with gilded and colored carving, with the narrower lanes behind them densely packed with smaller housing — a description of a working immigrant quarter that, more than a century later, both the street plan and the trade have outlasted.³

1923: rubble becomes a park

The Great Kanto earthquake struck Kannai as hard as anywhere in the city; the 1933 customs account of Chinatown alone records more than a thousand dead or injured in that one quarter. The recovery took a distinctively Yokohama form: the sea off Yamashita-cho's waterfront was designated a dumping ground for the earthquake's rubble, and between 1925 and 1930 that fill, topped with spoil from tunnel excavation and river dredging elsewhere in the city, was built up and landscaped into Yamashita Park, opened in 1930 as Japan's first purpose-built waterfront urban park, according to the Agency for Cultural Affairs' own heritage register. What had been open water in the 1859 settlement plan was now solid, public ground.³⁷

1945: burned again, and held by an occupying army

On the morning of 29 May 1945, some 517 American B-29 bombers dropped roughly 438,000 incendiary bombs on Yokohama in about an hour; the city's own official figures, issued shortly afterward, record 3,650 dead, 10,198 injured, 309 missing and 311,218 people left homeless, with the fire concentrated on Naka, Minami, Nishi and Kanagawa wards — Naka Ward holding Kannai and Chinatown both. The war's end did not return the district to ordinary life. Occupation forces requisitioned central Yokohama and its port facilities so broadly, the city's own account states, that municipal government almost stopped functioning: offices, department stores, theaters, schools and parks were all taken over, and the outbreak of the Korean War in June 1950 delayed their release still further. Requisitioned land came back only piecemeal over the following decade and a half — the Osanbashi pier in February 1952, Yokohama Park that April, and the housing built on Yamashita Park's own grounds not until June 1960, nearly fifteen years after the surrender.⁵⁶

Reading the ground today

The five streets the shogunate laid out to win its argument over Kanagawa — the waterfront road and the parallel streets behind it — still organize Kannai's grid today, running at a slight angle to the rest of the city that marks them as the oldest planned streets in Yokohama; the 1859 land-division plan in the city's own map archive lines up remarkably closely with the street plan a modern aerial photograph shows on the ground now. Chinatown's gates stand roughly where lots 120 to 160 once ran, home under the trade association's own count to more than 400 shops and restaurants, on the same footprint an 1871 treaty and a compradors' economy first filled in. Yamashita Park's lawns remain, functionally, the flattened remains of 1923's

destruction, and the requisitioned buildings that once stood in for a defeated capital's own damaged offices are gone, but the decade-and-a-half gap between surrender and return is still legible in how late, relative to the rest of Japan, central Yokohama's postwar rebuilding properly began. ¹⁴⁶⁹

Timeline

1181	Gumyoji temple, the oldest documented place name within today's Yokohama City, appears in a historical record. ²
17th century	The fishing hamlet of Yokohama-mura splits off from Ishikawa village, reaching 87 households. ¹
1858-1859	Treaty negotiations substitute Yokohama for the named treaty port of Kanagawa; a customs house is built at the village's center, giving Kannai its name. ¹
January 1861	The Dutch consulate agrees to move to Yokohama, and other powers follow despite their governments' preference for Kanagawa. ¹
1860-1863	Yokohama village's farmers are relocated and the foreign settlement is built southward, substantially complete by 1863. ³
13 September 1871	Japan and China sign their first treaty of amity and commerce, formalising the status of the Chinese residents already settled at Yamashita-cho. ³
1877	A Qing consulate opens in Nankin-machi at lot 135. ³
1 September 1923	The Great Kanto earthquake devastates Kannai and Chinatown; the city begins dumping rubble into the sea off Yamashita-cho. ³
1930	Yamashita Park opens on reclaimed earthquake rubble, Japan's first purpose-built waterfront urban park. ⁷
29 May 1945	The Great Yokohama Air Raid burns Naka, Minami, Nishi and Kanagawa wards; the city records 3,650 dead. ⁵
1945-1960	Occupation forces requisition central Yokohama; the last of the Yamashita Park land is not returned until June 1960. ⁶

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1

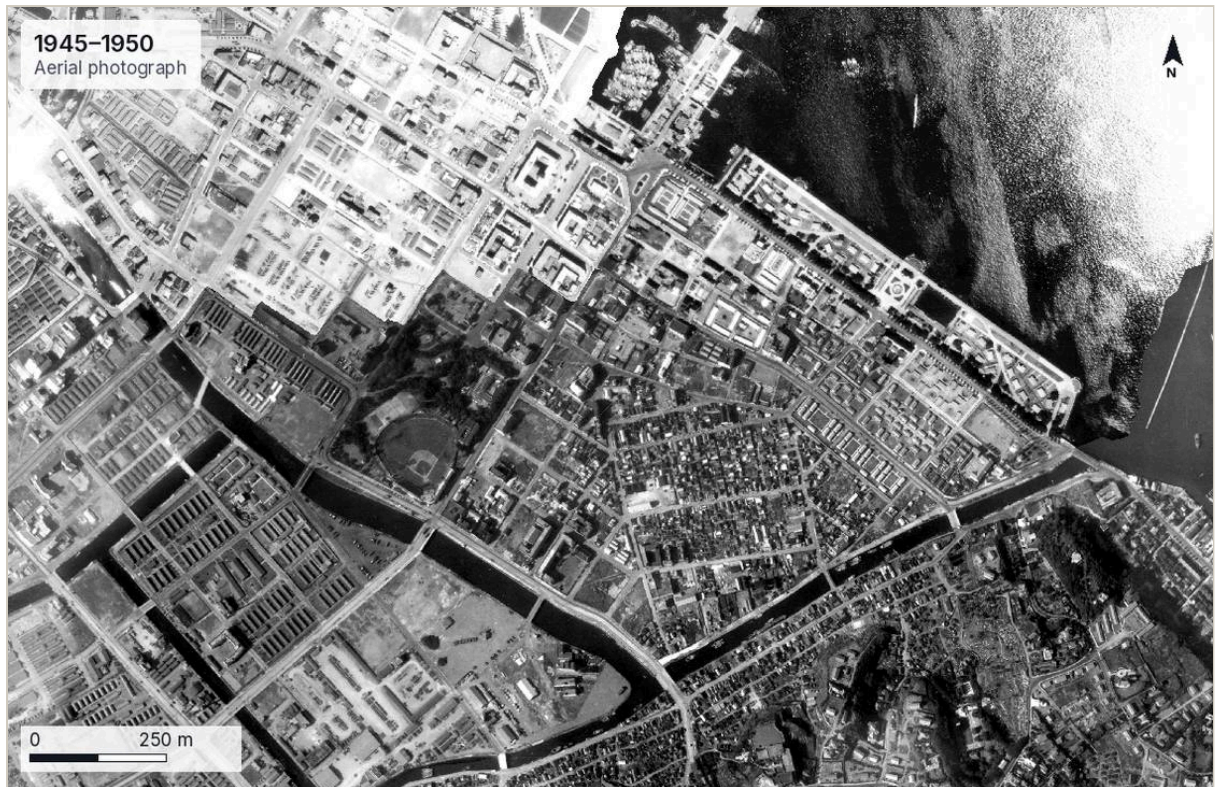
The former customs-house site, Nihon-odori 日本大通り. Near the center of the reclaimed 1859 settlement, where the shogunate's customs post gave Kannai ("inside the barrier") its name; Nihon-odori and the five original settlement streets still run on their 1859 alignment.¹
- 2

Yokohama Chinatown 横浜中華街. Occupies the former lots 120-160 of the foreign settlement, home to Chinese residents since the 1860s and, per its own trade association, more than 400 shops and restaurants today.³¹⁰
- 3

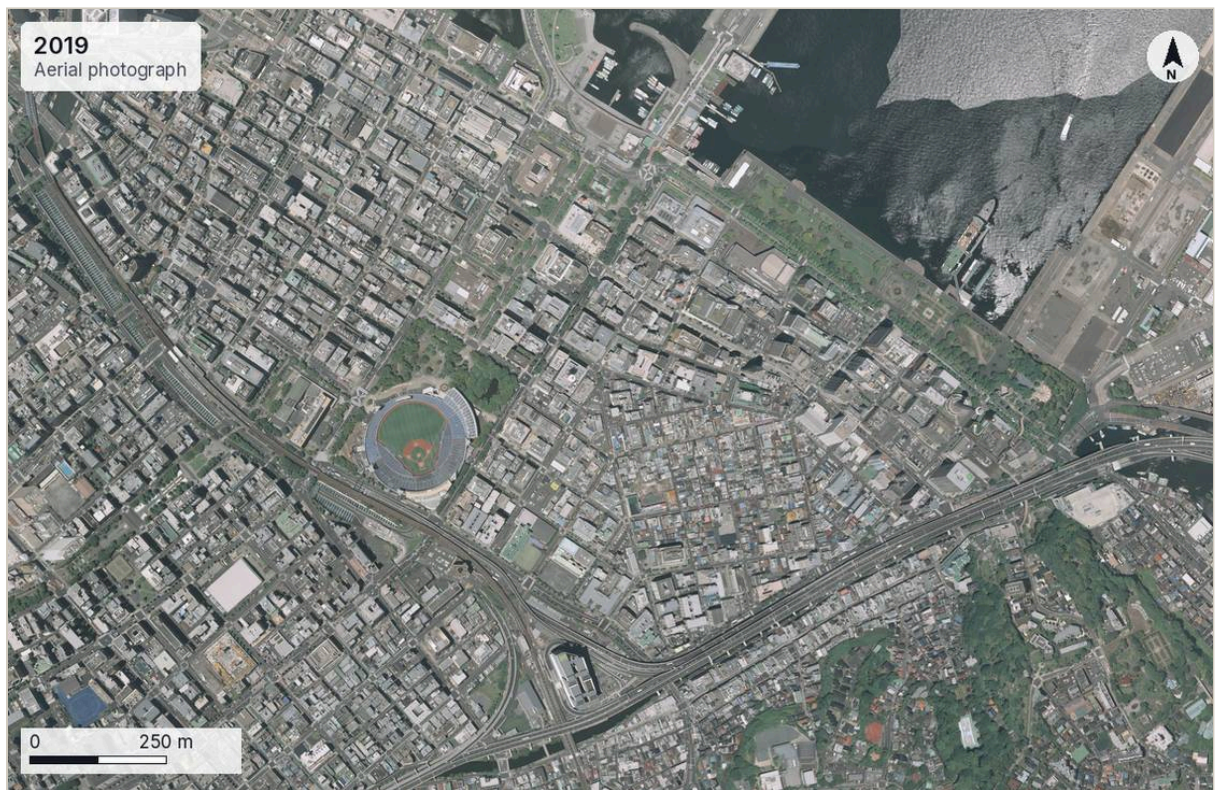
Yamashita Park 山下公園. Built from 1923 earthquake rubble between 1925 and 1930, Japan's first purpose-built waterfront park; requisitioned housing on its grounds was not returned to the city until June 1960.⁶⁷
- 4

Yokohama Park (former racecourse and settlement land) 横浜公園. Laid out on former settlement ground and itself requisitioned by occupation forces from 1945, only partly released in April 1952, one of many central Yokohama sites held by the US military for years after the war.⁶

The same ground, 1945–1950 and 2019



1945–1950 aerial photograph (US military photography) — GSI Tiles *ort_USA10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2019 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2019*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

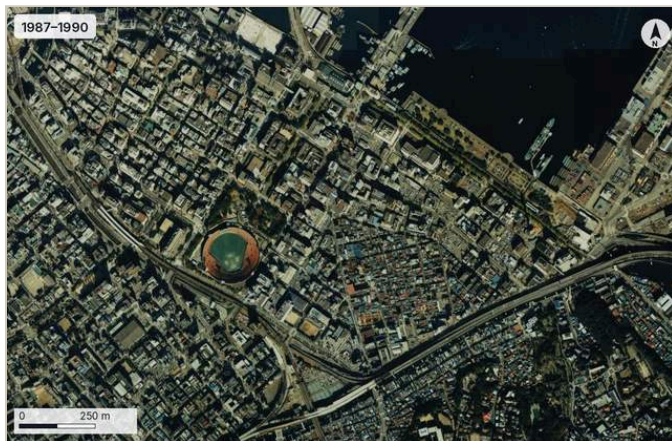
Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1961-1969 · GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, processed



1974-1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed



1987-1990 · GSI Tiles *gazo4*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

Former water area 57%	Sandbars and dunes 15%
Water 14%	Mountain and hill slopes 4.8%
Foothill deposits 4.0%	Floodplain and coastal plain 2.3%
Plateaus and terraces 2.0%	Cliffs and terrace scarps 0.7%

What the main landforms mean

Former water area (57%). Land shown by old maps and aerial photographs to have been sea, lake, pond, reservoir or river, later turned into land. Soft ground: very strong liquefaction tendency where filled, strong where drained. Storm surge near the coast.

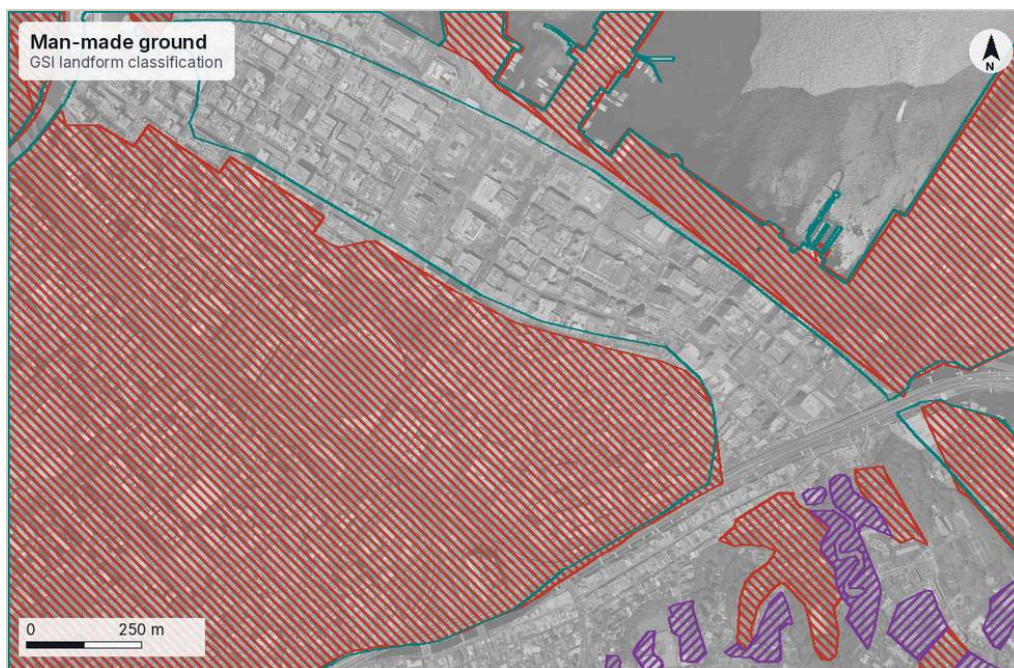
Sandbars and dunes (15%). Sandy or gravelly ground higher than its surroundings along present or former coasts, lakeshores and riverbanks, built by waves or wind. Usually escapes ordinary floods. Liquefaction tendency is somewhat strong on sandbars, somewhat weak on dunes and very strong at dune margins.

Mountain and hill slopes (4.8%). Ridges, valleys and fairly steep ground, including terrace-scarp slopes and volcanic ground. Heavy rain or earthquakes can trigger slope failures, debris flows and landslides.

Foothill deposits (4.0%). Gentler ground below mountains and scarps, built from debris brought down by slope failures and debris flows. Debris flows are possible in heavy rain; the ground is unstable and slopes may fail in earthquakes.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

Man-made ground

-  Filled and reclaimed land 54%
-  Cut ground 2.1%

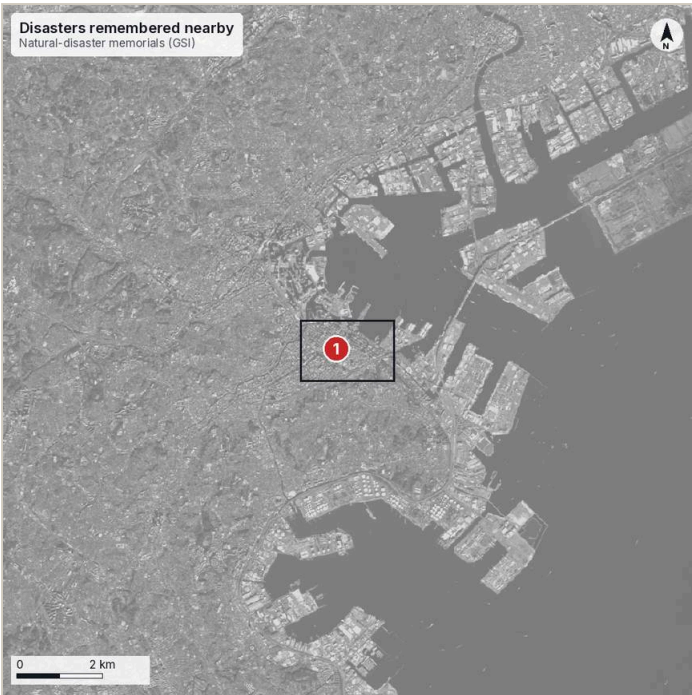
Filled and reclaimed land (54%). Ground raised with fill, land made by dumping soil into the sea, rivers or ponds, or valleys filled in. May flood if not raised enough; on hills, rain or earthquakes can make the fill fail; in lowlands the liquefaction tendency is very strong, especially on filled sea, lake or river beds.

Cut ground (2.1%). Ground made by cutting into slopes of mountains or terrace edges. Depending on the cut slope, heavy rain or earthquakes may bring it down; the ground itself is generally firm.

Meiji-era lowland

-  River, pond or sea 28%
-  Reed beds under 0.5%

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 16 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 8 km are listed.

Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1 Monument to the reconstruction after the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake 復興記念碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1929	0.3 km

What the memorials record

1. Monument to the reconstruction after the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake. In the Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923, the former city of Yokohama had 28,169 buildings completely destroyed and 26,623 people killed. Yokohama Park, where the monument stands, served as a refuge for many of the city's residents during the disaster.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

1. 石野瑛 (Ishino Ei), 横浜 [Yokohama], 1913; NDL frames 44, 45, 52, 53, 54. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/947782/1/44> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Pre-port Yokohama village's formation and name origin; the Kanagawa-to-Yokohama treaty-port substitution and the founding of the customs house that gave Kannai its name.
2. 横浜市編 (Yokohama City, ed.), 横浜市史稿 政治編一 [Draft history of Yokohama City, Politics vol. 1], 1933; NDL frames 25, 90. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1213598/1/25> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: The oldest documented place names in the Yokohama region and medieval land-holding records, for background depth of settlement.
3. 横浜市編 (Yokohama City, ed.), 横浜市史稿 風俗編 [Draft history of Yokohama City, Customs vol.], 1933; NDL frames 394, 395. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1213723/1/394> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Nankin-machi's boundaries, population history, the 1871 treaty, the 1923 earthquake's toll there, and a description of the quarter's streets.
4. 横浜市編 (Yokohama City, ed.), 横浜市史稿 附図 [Draft history of Yokohama City, map volume], 1933; NDL frames 8, 11. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1213743/1/8> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login)). Used for: Two map plates: "Yokohama Village and its surroundings, 1851" and "Yokohama port-opening land-division map, 1859," used as primary visual evidence of the village's pre-port and settlement-era layout.
5. 解説 (横浜大空襲) [Commentary: the Great Yokohama Air Raid], 横浜市 (City of Yokohama). <https://www.city.yokohama.lg.jp/city-info/yokohamashi/gaiyo/shishiryu/showa/digital-archives/daikushu/comment3.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Official figures and details of the 29 May 1945 air raid.
6. 戦後の接収と市街地の返還 (昭和20年～昭和36年) [Postwar requisition and the return of the urban area, 1945-1961], 横浜市 (City of Yokohama). <https://www.city.yokohama.lg.jp/city-info/seisaku/torikumi/kichi/sesshu/yokohama-rekishi01.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The scope of the 1945 Occupation requisition of central Yokohama and the timetable of returns through 1961.
7. 山下公園 [Yamashita Park], 文化庁 文化遺産オンライン (Agency for Cultural Affairs, Cultural Heritage Online). <https://online.bunka.go.jp/heritages/detail/164701>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Yamashita Park's construction from 1923 earthquake rubble, its 1930 opening, and its wartime requisition and 1960 return to full public use.
8. 地形分類 (自然地形・人工地形) ベクトルタイル [Landform classification (natural and artificial) vector tiles], 国土地理院 (Geospatial Information Authority of Japan). https://github.com/gsi-cyberjapan/experimental_landformclassification, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Classification of the study area as predominantly former water, sandbar and artificial fill.
9. 地理院タイル 空中写真 (米軍撮影ほか) 及び全国最新写真 (シームレス) [GSI Tiles: aerial photographs (including US forces) and current seamless photographs], 国土地理院 (Geospatial Information Authority of Japan). <https://maps.gsi.go.jp/development/ichiran.html>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Basis for comparing historical and present-day aerial photography of the study area.
10. 横浜中華街公式サイト [Yokohama Chinatown official site], 横浜中華街発展会協同組合 (Yokohama Chinatown Development Association). <https://www.chinatown.or.jp/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: Current shop numbers and the association's own framing of Chinatown's history.

Further reading

- 横浜市史 第2巻 (横浜市編, 1959) — Yokohama City's full postwar-compiled history, covering the settlement, Chinatown and the 1923 and 1945 disasters in far more depth than this dossier. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/3013494> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 横浜市震災誌 第1冊 (横浜市市史編纂係編, 1926) — Open online but not read this session; the city's own contemporary record of the 1923 earthquake, likely with Kannai-specific detail. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/981919> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))
- 中区・中区制50周年記念事業実行委員会編『横浜・中区史：人びとが語る激動の歴史』(1985) — Naka Ward's own commemorative history, the ward that contains this entire study area. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9522877> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- 帝都復興史 附・横浜復興記念史 第1・3巻 (復興調査協会編, 1930) — Open online but not read this session; a contemporary account of Yokohama's reconstruction, including Yamashita Park's construction. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1259253> (open online (NDL Digital Collections, no login))

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- **Individual foreign and Chinese merchant-house records for the Kannai and Yamashita-cho settlement lots** — Yokohama Archives of History (横浜開港資料館). Consult their lot-by-lot settlement registers and foreign-firm records; request reading-room access.
- **Street-level requisition records for specific Kannai buildings, 1945-1960** — Yokohama City Archives (横浜市史資料室) and Kanagawa Prefectural Archives. Search their occupation-era property files and any surviving GHQ correspondence held locally.
- **Named casualty and building-loss records for Chinatown in the 1923 earthquake specifically** — Yokohama Archives of History and the Yokohama Chinatown Development Association's own historical materials. Ask the Development Association about any surviving community records from the reconstruction period.

- **US and Allied occupation photographic and administrative records of requisitioned Kannai buildings** — US National Archives (NARA): GHQ/SCAP and Eighth Army real estate records. Search the NARA catalog for Yokohama requisition files by building or district name.

Caveats

- No single date marks Yokohama's formal replacement of Kanagawa as the treaty port; this dossier follows historians' conventional use of 1 July 1859 (2 June by the old lunisolar calendar, still kept as Yokohama's official Port Opening Day), while noting that this date technically derives from Kanagawa's own designated opening.
- Casualty and population figures for Nankin-machi in the 1923 earthquake and interwar period come from the city's own 1933 customs-history volume and are not independently cross-checked against a second source in this session.
- Some medieval land-tenure detail drawn from the 1933 Yokohama City history (S2) concerns the wider Yokohama region rather than sites confirmed to lie inside this district's exact study radius, and is used only as general background on the area's depth of settlement.

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